The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

In an impassioned **state-of-the-union** address President Joe Biden urged Congress to “stand up” to Vladimir Putin and provide more support to Ukraine. Mr Biden warned that Russia’s aggression would “not stop at Ukraine”. He described the war in Gaza as “gut-wrenching”, and urged Israel to allow more aid to enter Gaza. In an unusually partisan address, Mr Biden made several attacks on Donald Trump, whom he said had sought to “bury the truth” about the attack on the Capitol in 2021.

Mr Biden also announced that America, in co-operation with the EU and Britain, would build a temporary pier off **Gaza’s** coast that would be used to deliver aid. Construction could begin as early as Sunday and could take between one and two months to complete. The UN says that hundreds of thousands of people are at risk of famine, especially in northern Gaza, where the population is almost totally cut off from aid.

Hong Kong published a draft of a new national-security law. It includes five new offences: treason; insurrection; sabotage endangering national security; foreign interference; and theft of state secrets and espionage. Some carry potential sentences of life imprisonment. The bill, designed to work in tandem with a national-security law imposed on Hong Kong by China in 2020, arrived at the legislature on Friday.

France and **Moldova** signed economic and defence deals as part of a French-led effort to resist Russian aggression. Last week Transnistria, a pro-Russian separatist region in Moldova, called on the Kremlin for assistance. Emmanuel Macron, France’s president,

said his country would provide “unwavering support” for the “independence, sovereignty and territorial integrity” of Moldova.

Canada reeled from an attack in which six Sri Lankans, including a mother and her four children, were stabbed to death in Ottawa, the capital. The family’s father was also wounded in the incident. A 19-year-old Sri Lankan man was arrested and charged. Mass murders in Canada are rare. Ottawa, which is home to 1m people, saw 14 murders in 2023.

Jij, a Japanese news agency, reported that the **Bank of Japan** is planning to review its “yield-curve control” bond-buying scheme. Since 2016 the BoJ has pursued an expensive interventionist policy to keep yields on ten-year bonds near zero. But over the past two years the approach has come under pressure as inflation has risen. The yen rose on the news.

Officials detected another mass bleaching in Australia’s **Great Barrier Reef.** The discolouration of the world’s largest coral system is caused by rising sea temperatures. Warmer waters force corals to lose the algae that give them colour. It is the fifth time in eight years that the reef has been damaged this way. The UN warns that it is under “serious threat”.

Figure of the day: $69,000, the value of a bitcoin token at its all-time high on March 5th. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America’s presidential election, we’ve launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.

Photo: AP

A cooler job market in America

After what appeared to be a blockbuster start to 2024, the American labour market now looks a little calmer. In February it added 275,000 jobs, more than expected, but the initial figure of 350,000 for January was revised down to 230,000, according to data released on Friday. This more modest growth is exactly what the Federal Reserve and investors had hoped to see. The surge in January fuelled concerns that growth and inflation were accelerating again, which could have forced the Fed to keep interest rates higher for longer.

Instead, a moderate softening may clear the way for the central bank to start cutting rates in the coming months. There are some faint signs: workers who lose their jobs are taking longer to find new ones, and wage growth is tailing off. But at the same time the economy is running well clear of a recession: the unemployment rate only ticked slightly higher to 3.9%. It remains near a five-decade low.

Photo: Rex Shutterstock

Orban meets Trump

On Friday Viktor Orban, Hungary's prime minister, will meet Donald Trump at his estate in Florida, Mar-a-Lago. He is not planning to stop in Washington to meet the president, Joe Biden. Mr Orban believes that he and Mr Trump are at the vanguard of an international alliance against globalism. Both of them espouse a virulent new style of conservatism based on nationalism, opposition to international migration and the view that woke ideas are taking over Western culture.

Mr Orban is isolated within the European Union and NATO because he tramples the rule of law in Hungary and staunchly opposes military aid to Ukraine. A Republican victory in America's presidential election would improve his standing. He is one of only a few international leaders who would welcome a win by Mr Trump in November. Many dread the prospect.

Photo: Reuters

Ireland’s liberalising referendum proposals

On Friday the Irish public began voting in two referendums on proposals to modernise the constitution. Voters will decide whether to scrap language referring to women’s “life within the home” and to offer constitutional recognition to families not founded on marriage.

The referendums are taking place on International Women’s Day. The proposals have the support of almost all parliamentary parties. The constitution was written in 1937, when the influence of the Catholic church was much stronger. But the country has recently become more liberal: it voted decisively in favour of legalising same-sex marriage in 2015 and abortion in 2018.

Some government politicians worry that the proposals will be defeated. The Yes campaign has been lacklustre, and turnout is expected to be low. Among the people who may be motivated to show up are voters angry about a cost-of-living crisis and a housing shortage: they may use the polls to rebuke the establishment. A growing anti-immigrant movement could do the same. Leo

Varadkar, the prime minister, said that defeat would be a “setback for Ireland”.

Photo: EPA

A welcome drop in food prices

Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022 sent global prices of foodstuffs soaring. Food insecurity subsequently rose in poor countries. Prices have come down since 2023, mostly owing to bumper Russian wheat exports and a global expansion in agricultural production in response to high prices. In addition, overall inflation depressed demand for some commodities, especially sunflower oil.

The UN Food and Agriculture Organisation’s food-price index, which tracks international prices, fell in February by 10.5% compared with a year earlier. The index was at its lowest level since early 2021.

But it is not all sweet news. The FAO’s sugar-price index was 12.5% higher in February than a year earlier. El Niño, a climate pattern, has caused droughts in Australia, India and Thailand—three of the four biggest exporters of sugar. That will be bitter for folk with a sweet tooth.

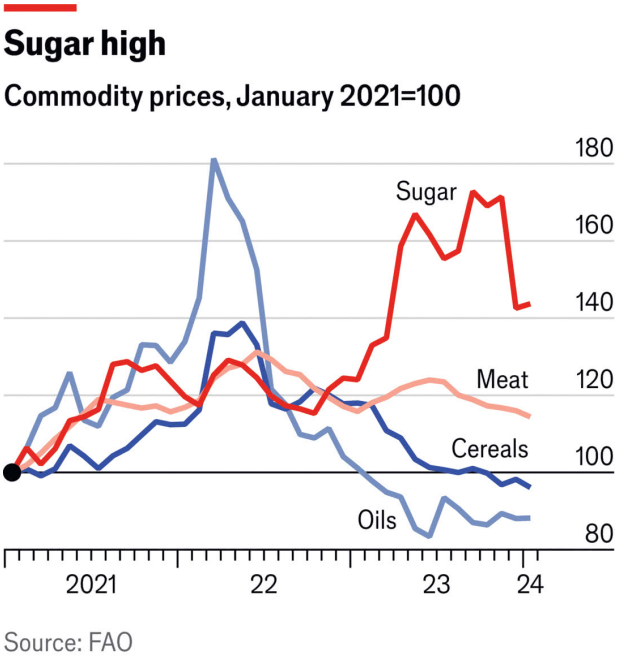


Photo: Rex Shutterstock

Ariana Grande returns

Absence makes the heart grow fonder. Or so hopes Ariana Grande. The pop star released six albums in the seven years to 2020. Her fans have had to wait another four for her seventh album, “Eternal Sunshine”, released on Friday. Ms Grande recorded it during the recent Hollywood strikes, which paused the filming of “Wicked”, a pair of musical films in which she stars.

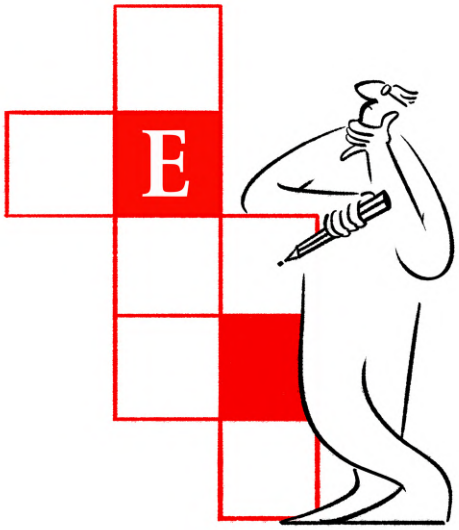
There has been no spate of singles, nor have previews been made available to critics. Ms Grande wants her fans to “experience” the album for the first time in its entirety. She has released only one song, with the characteristically insouciant title of “Yes, And?”. The house-music bop soared right to the top of the Billboard Hot 100 chart. Sources at her record company, Republic Records, have promised more of the same on the album.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We’ll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Friday: Which 1970 movie saw Ryan O’Neal romance Ali McGraw?

Thursday: What is the term for a knitted jumper that buttons up?



The winners of last week's crossword

Thank you to everyone who took part in our weekly crossword, published in the weekend edition of Espresso. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nezar Chakaki, Leawood, Kansas, America
Peter Grodzinski, London, Britain
Apple Schubert, Munich, Germany

They all gave the correct answers of Marine Le Pen, Malbec, ethnic and nature. Check back tomorrow for this week's crossword.

> *Presidents come and go, but the Supreme Court goes on forever.*
>
> *William Howard Taft*